

STAGE FIFTEEN • BUSINESS & ORGANIZATIONAL ACUMEN

# FIRSTS

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## ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

*Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers*

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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## FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

*Stage Fifteen • Business & Organizational Acumen*

### PURPOSE

Stage Fifteen runs across three sessions — Understanding How Organizations Work, Analyzing the Business, and Strategic & Reflective Business Thinking — each gets one icebreaker below, built directly from that session's actual content.

Because this stage is fundamentally analytical, these openers are designed to produce a small, genuine “aha” before any formal teaching begins — a gap in someone's own explanation, a real bottleneck they've personally experienced, a perspective shift they didn't expect to find useful. Each one previews, in miniature, the exact skill the session's formal FIRSTS are about to build.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

## Three Openers, One Per Session

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### SESSION 1

#### Explain It to a Stranger

TIME: 10 min

1. In pairs, each person has 60 seconds to explain how their organization (a current job, internship, or one they know well) actually makes money — no notes, first attempt.
2. Partner listens for one thing: did that explanation describe the product, or the actual revenue mechanism? The two aren't always the same.
3. Quick full-group show of hands: who found this genuinely harder to explain clearly than expected?

##### WHY THIS WORKS

*This surfaces, before any formal teaching, the exact gap FIRST S1 is built on — that most people can describe what their organization does long before they can clearly explain how it actually makes money.*

### SESSION 2

#### The Bottleneck Hunt

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask the group: “think of a process you've experienced as a customer or employee that felt genuinely slow or broken — what was the actual holdup?” Quick round-robin, one sentence each.
2. Facilitator collects the answers visibly (whiteboard or shared doc) without commentary yet.
3. Ask: how many of those holdups happened at a handoff between two people or teams, rather than within one person's own work?

##### WHY THIS WORKS

*This produces, in the group's own real experience, the exact pattern FIRST S12 (Process Mapping Exercise) is built to find — that the most costly bottlenecks usually live at handoffs, not within any single person's task.*

### SESSION 3

#### Zoom Out One Level

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask each participant to name one decision they've made recently, at work, school, or personally, purely from their own immediate perspective.
2. In pairs, each person tries to reconsider their partner's decision from one level up — what would a parent, manager, or mentor weigh that the original decision-maker might not have?
3. Quick full-group tally: how many pairs found the “zoomed out” view genuinely added a consideration that was missing?

**WHY THIS WORKS**

*This is a fast, low-stakes rehearsal of the exact perspective-shift FIRST S21 (Executive Perspective Exercise) asks for later in the session, making the formal exercise feel like a natural continuation rather than a cold start.*